

Generational Differences in Expectations of State Responsibility in China

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1. Introduction

Recent developments in China suggest that citizens do not all hold shared expectations toward the role of the state. These variations are particularly pronounced across generations shaped by distinct historical and institutional experiences. To analyze these differences with conceptual precision, we use the term ‘government responsibility’ to describe the state’s expected role in intervening across major spheres of collective life, notably social, economic, and political. Likewise, following Mannheim’s conceptualization of generations as socially constructed cohorts, we define ‘generational differences’ as variations in attitudes determined by the historical contexts and formative experiences that distinguish one cohort from another.¹ These generational differences become particularly visible in moments of social mobilization, where different generations engage and articulate demands according to distinct expectations of what the state should provide or protect. The first major protest that exposed generational differences in views of state responsibility emerged during the COVID-19 pandemic in response to perceived policy failures. Journalist accounts note that the white paper protests (白纸运动) were “predominantly led by young adults and university students”, indicating that younger cohorts were more willing to publicly contest the government’s handling of the crisis.²

Yet, the absence of older cohorts cannot be taken as a political disagreement with the movement’s claims. Their non-participation may be attributed to differences in capacity for participation, including reduced mobility, vulnerability in the face of COVID-19, and more limited access to the digital channels mobilized by younger generations. Media coverage reported that information about the protests first disseminated online: “images and videos circulated online showed students at universities in cities including Nanjing and Beijing holding up blank sheets of paper in silent protest”.³ Such digitally inclined forms of coordination align with Brinkerhoff’s notion of ‘diasporic groups’, referring to those who “leverage digital media to negotiate their identities, sustain relationships, and engage in transnational activities”.⁴ These online modes of communication are far more prevalent among younger populations than older citizens. Nonetheless, these conditions of participation do not undermine variations in political expectations; rather, they help illuminate why younger cohorts publicly articulate discontent while older cohorts remain largely absent from collective action.

Another example of a generational divergence, this time beyond public health, is the emergence of the ‘lying flat movement’ (躺平). This response to structural pressures and unmet social expectations illustrates how younger cohorts reject the intense labor competition and traditional success markers that older generations often regard as ‘normal’. Survey evidence reinforces this divide: “Millennial employees

¹ Mannheim, Karl. 1952. “The Problem of Generations.” *Essays on the Sociology of Knowledge*, 276-322. London: Routledge.

² Amnesty International, “China’s White Paper Movement: One Year On, Six Protesters Share Their Stories,” *Amnesty International*, November 27, 2023, <https://www.amnesty.org/en/latest/campaigns/2023/11/chinas-white-paper-movement-one-year-on-six-protesters-share-their-stories/>; Zeng, Jing, and Calvin Yixiang Cheng. “Diasporic Citizen Journalism: Exploring the Discussion on the 2022 Blank Paper Protests in the Chinese Twitter Community.” *Journalism*, vol. 26, no. 5, 2025, pp. 1047-1066. SAGE Journals, <https://doi.org/10.1177/14648849241250191>

³ Martin Quin Pollard and Brenda Goh, “Blank Sheets of Paper Become Symbol of Defiance in China Protests,” *Reuters*, November 28, 2022, <https://www.reuters.com/world/china/blank-sheets-paper-become-symbol-defiance-china-protests-2022-11-27/>

⁴ Jennifer M. Brinkerhoff, *Digital Diasporas: Identity and Transnational Engagement* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2009), 22.

were found to show the highest preference for both extrinsic and intrinsic work values, followed by the Social Reform generation, whereas the Cultural Revolution generation scored lowest.”⁵ Extrinsic values include recognition, status and a sense of belonging, while intrinsic values refer to accomplishment, confidence and personal competence. By contrast, older cohorts, having experienced the planned-economy era, display stronger attachment to “system-values”, such as hierarchy, obedience and job security.⁶ What this reveals is a fundamental contradiction in work expectations: younger generations increasingly view work as a site of personal fulfilment, whereas older cohorts interpret work primarily through the lens of duty and stability. This contrast highlights a clear generational divide in how work pressures and state responsibility are interpreted in contemporary China.

1. Literature Review

This chapter reviews existing scholarship on how citizens conceptualize the role of the state, how political trust is formed, and how socialization and historical memory shape political attitudes. While extensive research has examined state-society relations in China, these studies have not fully addressed why different generations hold distinct expectations of what the government should provide or protect. The following sections outline three bodies of literature and identify gaps that motivate this study.

2.1 How Citizens Conceptualize the State

Western political theory conceptualizes the state as a response to the dangers of disorder. Hobbes famously argued that, without a sovereign authority, human life would return to a “state of nature,” characterized by insecurity and conflict.⁷ Rousseau extended this reasoning by grounding legitimacy in collective agreement and the “general will,” which authorizes state intervention for common purposes.⁸ More recently, Habermas reframed political legitimacy in procedural terms, arguing that modern governance must rely on communicative justification and public reasoning.⁹

However, scholars of Asian political thought note that these contractual paradigms do not adequately describe the foundations of legitimacy in non-Western contexts. Rather than locating legitimacy in past consent, many East Asian traditions frame authority through the persistent fear of social chaos, and this is what some historians term as “the danger of primitive power”, meaning the return of chaos if centralized authority weakens.¹⁰ In such contexts, citizens often tolerate or even expect stronger paternalistic governance, viewing the state primarily as the guardian of stability and moral order.

Contemporary studies of Chinese governance build on this perspective. Scholars have described China’s political model as “responsive authoritarianism” or “consultative Leninism,” emphasizing a combination of centralized control, pragmatic problem-solving, and selective responsiveness to societal

⁵ Jun Yang, Chun-Sheng Yu, and Jun Wu, “Work Values Across Generations in China,” *Chinese Management Studies* 12, no. 4

⁶ Ibid.

⁷ Thomas Hobbes, *Leviathan* (London: Andrew Crooke, 1651)

⁸ Jean-Jacques Rousseau, *The Social Contract*, trans. Maurice Cranston (London: Penguin, 1968).

⁹ Jürgen Habermas, “The Public Sphere: An Encyclopedia Article,” *New German Critique* 3, no. 1 (1989): 45-56.

¹⁰ He Baogang, “Consultative Leninism,” *Political Studies* 59, no. 4 (2011): 626-642; Jessica Teets, *Civil Society under Authoritarianism: The China Model* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2014).

demands. Within this framework, citizens frequently assess the state not through liberal notions of autonomy or rights, but through its capacity to manage risk, correct market failures, and maintain societal harmony. Existing theories suggest that the conceptualization of the state is inseparable from deeper cultural narratives about order and authority. These foundations help explain why different generations anchor their expectations of the state in divergent normative assumptions.

2.2 Political Trust and the Foundations of State-Society Relations

There is also rich literature about political trust and state-society relations, mostly distinguished by cultural and institutional explanations. Mishler and Rose argue that trust may originate from early socialization or emerge through rational evaluations of political performance.¹¹ Rothstein's influential theory emphasizes impartiality in public service provision as a crucial determinant of political trust, highlighting the importance of procedural justice in sustaining state legitimacy.¹²

In the Chinese context, post-reform governance has reshaped the bases of trust. Hoffman shows how public service provision increasingly adopts a consumerist logic, with citizens evaluating government performance through expectations of efficiency, transparency, and predictability.¹³ Zhang and Ong examine how market reforms create new forms of insecurity, highlighting citizens' concerns about arbitrariness and the uneven distribution of institutional protection.¹⁴ Meanwhile, Sun argues that the erosion of collective welfare structures has generated a "risk society," where citizens become structurally dependent on the state for security and basic welfare.¹⁵

These perspectives illuminate why Chinese citizens often rely on the state as the primary guarantor of social order and welfare. However, they tend to focus on society-level trends rather than intergenerational variation. Consequently, they do not account for whether different generations internalize institutional changes in distinct ways, nor how divergent life-course experiences shape contrasting interpretations of state responsibility.

2.3 Socialization, Memory, and Political Attitudes

Regarding political trust, the formation of political attitudes is also important, and most theories were developed through the idea of early socialization and collective memory, particularly in rapidly transforming societies.

Karl Mannheim's foundational work on generations argues that individuals who experience major historical events during youth develop lasting interpretive frameworks that shape political attitudes across the life course.¹⁶ Later research confirms that political orientations are strongly influenced by formative environments, including education systems, ideological messages, and exposure to state institutions.¹⁷

¹¹ William Mishler and Richard Rose, "What Are the Origins of Political Trust? Testing Institutional and Cultural Theories in Post-Communist Societies," *Comparative Political Studies* 34, no. 1 (2001): 30-62.

¹² Bo Rothstein, *The Quality of Government: Corruption, Social Trust, and Inequality in International Perspective* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2011)

¹³ Lisa Hoffman. 2017. "Bureaucratic Neoliberalism in Urban China." *Urban Studies* 54 (13): 3058-3074.

¹⁴ Zhang, Li, and Aihwa Ong. 2008. "Privatizing China." *China Journal* 60: 1-20.

¹⁵ Sun, Liping. 2009. "China's Risk Society." *Chinese Sociological Review* 42 (1): 5-25.

¹⁶ Karl Mannheim, "The Problem of Generations," in *Essays on the Sociology of Knowledge* (London: Routledge, 1952), 276-322.

¹⁷ Jennings and Niemi, "Continuities in Political Socialization" *American Political Science Review* (1974).

In China, political socialization has changed dramatically across cohorts. Older generations were shaped by strong ideological education and high state penetration in daily life, whereas middle generations were socialized during market reforms, decentralization, and increasing bureaucratic complexity. Younger generations, by contrast, grew up in an era of global information flows, digital governance, and rising expectations for procedural accountability.

While scholars have examined the influence of collective trauma, economic restructuring, and ideological change on political attitudes, little research has explored how different generations reinterpret the meaning of state responsibility under shared political institutions. Nor have existing studies addressed how memory interacts with changing informational and economic environments to produce generational divergence in expectations of state action.

Although prior research highlights the importance of socialization and memory, it does not examine how distinct generational experiences create different boundaries between what the state should regulate and what society should manage independently.

2.4 Gaps in the Literature

Despite substantial insights into political trust, state legitimacy, and socialization, several gaps remain:

1. Existing literature seldom investigates how citizens define the scope of government responsibility.
2. Studies of political socialization do not compare how generational contexts produce distinct interpretive frameworks.
3. Research has not examined the interaction between historical memory, market transition, and digital information environments in shaping generational differences.
4. Although the concept of primitive power helps explain legitimacy in China, no study has explored how different generations internalize this fear of disorder differently.

These gaps lead directly to the central question of this study. Given the limitations of existing research, this study asks whether younger and older Chinese citizens hold different expectations of what the government should provide and protect, and what mechanisms can explain these generational differences. While previous scholarship highlights the importance of political trust, institutional performance, and collective memory, it does not examine how citizens themselves draw boundaries between state responsibility and societal autonomy, nor how generational experiences, from socialist-era stability to market reforms to digital governance, shape these boundaries. This study therefore seeks to understand how different cohorts conceptualize the role of the state and why these conceptions diverge within a shared political system.

2. Problématique

Therefore, this project emerges from a set of contradictions identified both in established scholarship and in recent empirical analyses of Chinese society. While academics such as Lucian Pye characterize Chinese political culture as shaped by enduring “paternalistic expectations,” implying that citizens anticipate extensive state intervention in their lives, more recent scholarship complicates this traditional understanding.¹⁸ Yan Yunxiang, for instance, notes increasing frustration with “institutional constraints” among Chinese youth, while Hansen and Svarverud observe that many young Chinese seek to liberate themselves from these very structural conditions in order to “define their own futures.”¹⁹ Rather than signalling a simple decline in political trust, these shifts suggest an emerging reorientation toward personal autonomy that coexists with persistent expectations of state authority. Taken together, these contrasting attitudes reveal a broader tension: although the literature explains why the Chinese state has historically been viewed as the guarantor of order, especially given the cultural salience of avoiding social disorder or “primitive power”, it does not account for how different generations negotiate this tension, nor why they draw the boundary of state responsibility in divergent ways.²⁰

To address this question, the study first situates generational expectations of state responsibility within existing sociological debates, before conducting a qualitative comparison of younger and older cohorts to analyze how differences in socialization, memory, and lived experience shape these expectations. Accordingly, our research project therefore asks whether younger and older Chinese citizens hold different expectations of government responsibility, and where these generational differences originate.

3. Method Discussion

4.1 Fieldwork and Data sources

This study draws on original qualitative data collected through six semi-structured interviews conducted online with participants residing in Beijing. All respondents have spent the majority of their lives living in mainland China, ensuring sustained exposure to domestic institutions and state practices. Interviews were conducted in Mandarin to preserve semantic precision and ensure accuracy of meaning. Participants were recruited through personal networks using snowball sampling.

Three generational cohorts were defined: a Cultural Revolution cohort, a Reform cohort, and a Millennial cohort (born 1960s-1978, 1980s-1999 and 2000-present, respectively). Two participants were interviewed within each cohort, yielding a total sample of six respondents. Each cohort consists of one male and one female participant, allowing partial control for gender. The first cohort includes a manager (Co1-1) and a university professor (Co1-2); the second includes a lawyer (Co2-1) and a teacher (Co2-2); and the

¹⁸ Lucian Pye, *Asian Power and Politics: The Cultural Dimensions of Authority* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1985).

¹⁹ Yunxiang Yan, *The Individualization of Chinese Society* (Oxford: Berg, 2009)

Mette Halskov Hansen and Rune Svarverud, *iChina: The Rise of the Individual in Modern Chinese Society* (Copenhagen: NIAS Press, 2010).

²⁰For discussions of “primitive power” and the cultural fear of disorder in Chinese political legitimacy, see scholarship on East Asian political thought and Confucian statecraft traditions..

third includes two university students (Co3-1, Co3-2). While this design enables structured generational comparison, the sample remains socially selective and predominantly urban and highly educated.

4.2 Research Design and Method

The study employs semi-structured interviews to examine how citizens define government responsibility and to what extent these understandings are shaped by socialization and life-experiences. This method is preferred to more structured approaches as it allows respondents to articulate meanings in their own terms, rather than being confined to pre-determined categories that may otherwise restrict their reflections. The resulting narratives are subsequently situated within broader theoretical frameworks of political socialization, collective memory, and state-society relations.

Given the generational focus of the project, interviews were conducted within cohorts rather than across generations in order to minimize age-hierarchy dynamics associated with Confucian norms of deference that may inhibit open disagreement in a mixed-age setting.

4.3 Interview Structure

In order to obtain comparable answers across cohorts, all participants were asked the same four open-ended questions:

1. Perceptions of state responsibility

Question: When you think about the role of government today, which areas of life should be the state's responsibility, and which should be left to citizens?

Probes: Could you give an example? What is the government's job?

2. Transmission of attitudes

Question: From childhood to now, who or what shaped your view of what the state should do (eg parents, teachers, peers)?

Probes: Did your parents or family talk about the government at home? Did media (TV, internet, social media) influence how you think about the government? Did friends or classmates affect your views? Have your views changed since childhood? If yes, when and why?

3. Experiences of state interaction

Question: Please describe your most recent interaction with a public institution.

Probes: Was this interaction a positive or negative experience?

4. Accountability

Question: When government services do not work as expected, what exactly should the government do for you to consider the response fair?

Probes: Do you expect them to communicate with you (explanation, apology, updates)? What channel do you expect them to communicate with you (email, app, no need)?

Following these questions, participants were presented with anonymized excerpts from interviews conducted with another cohort and asked to respond. This procedure was designed to elicit explicit intergenerational comparison.

4.4 Ethical Considerations

All participants provided informed consent and were informed of their right to withdraw at any stage of the research. Pseudonyms are used, and all identifying details (workplace and precise location) have been removed to ensure anonymity. These measures are intended to protect participants' confidentiality and to create a secure environment in which they can express their views openly and meaningfully, thereby enhancing the reliability and accuracy of the data collected

4.5 Methodological limitations

A central limitation of this study concerns linguistic mediation. As one member of the research team does not speak Mandarin, access to the interview data was necessarily indirect and based entirely on translated scripts. This created an asymmetry in access to primary data, establishing a structural dependency on those conducting the interviews and producing the translations. Further, the use of translation poses semantic loss, particularly regarding culturally embedded expressions or idioms. Such terms are often formed from shared historical and cultural experiences, making them almost impossible to reproduce in another language without altering the meaning or the emotional intensity. In addition, generational differences in language use generates further uncertainty, as younger interviewers may not recognize certain expressions used by older respondents, potentially transmitting ambiguity into the transcript itself prior to translation. To mitigate these risks, translations were conducted collaboratively by both Mandarin-speaking researchers in order to limit interpretive bias. Ambiguous segments were documented and crosschecked against audio recordings to preserve tone, emphasis and contextual meaning. Following Temple & Young's assertion that translation requires attention beyond the lexical level, it is treated here as an interpretive process shaped by power and positionality.²¹ Accordingly, these limitations are understood as shaping the very conditions under which knowledge is produced, rather than as isolated factors external to the research process.

4. Findings

5.1 How do people define the role of the state?

Overall, the interviews across the three cohorts show that rather than sharing a single, uniform understanding of the role of the state, respondents rely on fundamentally different cognitive frameworks to define state responsibility and legitimacy. Cohort 1 tends to see the state as a moral and historical guardian whose main responsibility is to prevent chaos, contain primitive power, and secure basic welfare, which reflects their experience of famine, collectivism and war. Cohort 2 tends to define the state in terms of fairness, justice and public goods provision, asking whether the government corrects market failures and protects vulnerable groups in a marketized economy. Cohort 3 most often relies on a rights-institutions

²¹ Bogusia Temple and Alys Young, 'Qualitative Research and Translation Dilemmas', *Qualitative Research*, 4.2 (2004), 161-78
<https://knowledge.lancashire.ac.uk/id/eprint/4214/1/Qualitative%20research%20and%20translation%20dilemmas%20QR%2020041.pdf>

framework, using concepts like constitutional limits, rule-boundedness and transparency to imagine what the state should be and how far its responsibility should extend. Therefore, the role of the state is defined through moral-historical, fairness-oriented, and rights-based lenses rather than through a single baseline. These general patterns were strongly supported and illustrated by the empirical details from the interviews.

Across the interviews, the language and examples provided by respondents show how these frameworks are grounded in concrete experiences and reflections. The oldest cohort combines Marxist categories, lived experience and concerns about social stability from chaos originated from primitive power, and they emphasize that the state must *“take care of ordinary people”* in areas such as pensions and healthcare (Co1-2). The middle cohort describes the state through fairness, justice and public goods, with Teacher Z arguing that *“the state should take charge of social welfare and infrastructure construction”* when privatization and commercialization undermine equal access (Co2-2). The youngest cohort explicitly connects their views to global political theory and information norms, with Student L stating that *“free and truthful information exchange is the cornerstone of modern governance”* and insisting that legitimate authority must be “limited, rule-bound, and accountable” (Co3-1). This evidence shows that Cohort 1 ties state responsibility to stability and dignity, Cohort 2 ties it to equity in a market economy, and Cohort 3 ties it to rights and procedural legitimacy. Therefore, the three cohorts use different vocabularies to talk about the state.

5.2 What shaped their attitudes?

5.2.1 Cohort 1 - Shared generational experience

Cohort 1's attitudes towards the state are strongly shaped by shared generational memories of famine, collectivism and early reform. Their narrative centres on the experience of structural dispossession during the transition from collectivism to market reforms, and on the disappearance of traditional social buffers. *Professor X recalls his father's hard life in rural areas and links these memories to a belief that only a strong, interventionist state can replace the gap of the social welfare system, prevent exploitation and maintain a minimal standard of dignity (Co1-2).* This is not just a policy preference, but rather a way of seeing the world where, once society became uniformly “proletarian,” people were *“particularly prone to anxiety”* because they lacked independent resources to stabilize their lives (Co1-2). Manager Z's Marxist training and later philosophical reading are layered on top of such memories, producing a view in which the state must provide a stable “floor” of security, while the exact division of functions can be flexibly negotiated (Co1-1). This pattern suggests that Cohort 1's trust emerges from a practical need for protection formed in their youth. Therefore, their attitudes are grounded in shared generational experience of vulnerability and transition.

5.2.2 Cohort 2 - Economic opening and information exposure

Cohort 2's attitudes are shaped by memories of rapid economic growth with weak institutions, by the commercialization of public services, and by increased exposure to news and media reports of corruption. They grew up amid marketization and institutional mismatch, and their frustration with privatization and

commercialization is rooted in observing how profit-driven logic clashes with social need. The Beijing bus case mentioned during the interview inspired Teacher Z's argument that *"the state should take charge of social welfare and infrastructure construction"* to protect loss-making but socially necessary services and the vulnerable groups who rely on them (Co2-2). Lawyer T's memories of natural disasters and the state's role in coordinated rescue actions make them see the government as the only actor capable of crisis management, even as they remain aware of corruption and inefficiency (Co2-1). Their shared generational memory of rapid economic growth with mis-matching weak institutional facilities generates expectations that the state should be strong in regulation and public goods, but also more transparent and just. This pattern suggests that information exposure to corruption and institutional failures, rather than famine or collectivism, reshaped their early trust and pushed them to judge the state through fairness and performance. Therefore, Cohort 2's attitudes reflect the contradictions of economic opening and increased access to political and economic news.

5.2.3 Cohort 3 - Intellectual experience with Western ideologies

For Cohort 3, shared memory is less about dramatic material hardship and more about global comparison, mediated experience and intellectual engagement with Western political thought. Student L explicitly connects their views to political theory, explaining that reading Western thinkers like Hobbes and Foucault led them to see the state as necessary for order but also potentially dangerous if not constrained (Co3-1). This education supports the view that legitimate authority must be *"limited, rule-bound, and accountable"* (paraphrasing Co3-1), and thus supports their insistence on transparent communication: "free and truthful information exchange is the cornerstone of modern governance" (Co3-1). Student W's encounters with socioeconomic inequality through schooling with working-class peers and observing differences in access to opportunity lead to the view that unregulated markets cannot deliver justice and that the state should maintain strong public ownership and regulation in key sectors (Co3-2, paraphrased). Their shared memory is a society of information explosion with easy access to political and economic news, which translates into demands for both fairness and rights. This pattern suggests that intellectual experience and global references matter more for this cohort than early material conditions. Therefore, Cohort 3's attitudes are shaped by a combination of Western ideologies, digital information environments and lived inequality. However, these different sources of socialization only partly explain why the cohorts differ, and further analysis of generational memory, age and education is needed.

5.3 What caused the differences?

This section explains the reasons behind these generational differences, by linking respondents' expectations of state responsibility to shared generational memory, political socialization, and changing governance environments.

5.3.1 Impact of generational memory

The effect of shared generational memories become crucial in reasoning the difference since it lies in our main assumption. Shared memories of formative periods, including famine, collectivism and early

reform for Cohort 1, marketization and institutional mismatch for Cohort 2, and globalization and information explosion for Cohort 3, provide the emotional and cognitive background through which interviewees interpret state responsibility. For Cohort 1, Professor X's narrative centers on the experience of structural dispossession during the transition from collectivism to market reforms. He recalls his father's hard life in rural areas and the disappearance of traditional social buffers, linking these memories to a belief that only a strong, interventionist state can replace the gap of the social welfare system, prevent exploitation and maintain a minimal standard of dignity (Co1-2). This is not just a policy preference, but rather a way of seeing the world where, once society became uniformly "*proletarian*," people were "*particularly prone to anxiety*" because they lacked independent resources to stabilize their lives (Co1-2). Manager Z's Marxist training and later philosophical reading are layered on top of such memories, producing a view in which the state must provide a stable "floor" of security, while the exact division of functions can be flexibly negotiated (Co1-1).

Cohort 2's memories are different. They grew up instead amid rapid economic growth and weak social institutions. Teacher Z's frustration with privatization and commercialization is rooted in observing how profit-driven logic clashes with social need. The Beijing bus case mentioned during the interview inspired their argument that "the state should take charge of social welfare and infrastructure construction" to protect these groups (Co2-2). Lawyer T's memories of natural disasters and the state's role in coordinated rescue actions make them see the government as the only capable in crisis management, even as they remain aware of corruption and inefficiency (Co2-1). For this cohort, their shared generational memory of rapid economic growth with mis-matching weak institutional facilities generates their expectations that the state should be strong in regulation and public goods, but also more transparent and just.

For Cohort 3, shared memory is less about dramatic material hardship and more about global comparison and mediated experience. Student L's learning about events such as the Wukan village conflict and pandemic governance responses through media and academic reading (Co3-1) shapes a sense that the state must be both powerful and constrained. They stress that the government should protect life and order but must do so under conditions of "free and truthful information exchange" (Co3-1). Student W's encounters with socioeconomic inequality through schooling with working-class peers and observing differences in access to opportunity lead to the view that unregulated markets cannot deliver justice and that the state should maintain strong public ownership and regulation in key sectors (Co3-2, paraphrased). Their shared memory, instead of rapid market growth, is a society of information explosion with easy access to political and economic news, which translates into demands for both fairness and rights. In this sense, shared generational memory does not mechanically determine attitudes, but provides background narratives that shape what seems obvious or necessary: for Cohort 1, that the state must tightly manage society to prevent a return of chaos; for Cohort 2, that the state must correct market injustices; for Cohort 3, that the state must be both powerful and deeply accountable.

5.3.2 Impact of age

This subsection assesses whether the differences observed are mainly life-cycle effects or generational effects. Studies done by Harmel & Yeh in 2015 have already constructed a quantitative model shown as Figure 1., that older cohorts in other large-N

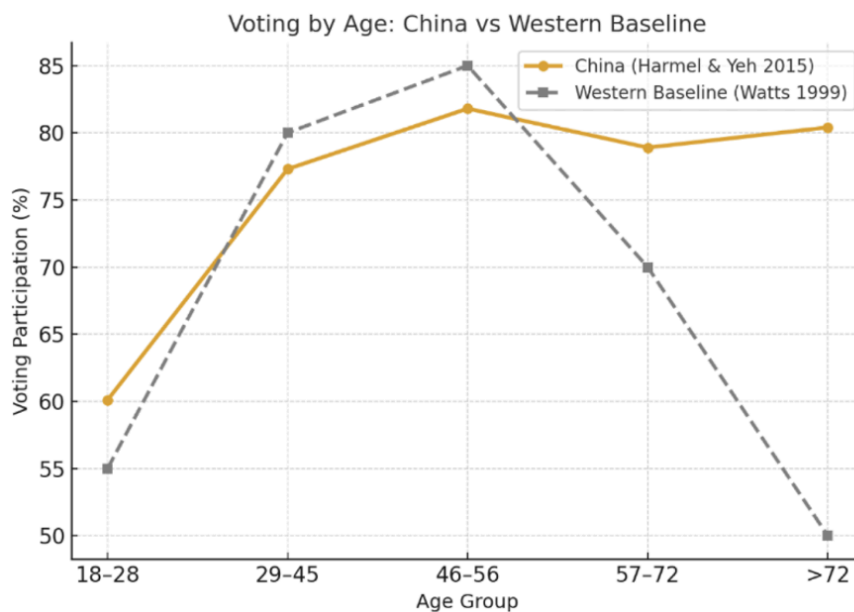


Figure 1. Non-Age Effect and the Western Baseline of Political Attitude

*Robert Harmel and Yu-Tzung Yeh, “Generational Differences in Political Participation in China: A Comparative Analysis,” *Journal of Chinese Political Science* 20, no. 2 (2015): 130, fig. 2.

studies often maintain high and relatively stable trust in central government over time, rather than converging to the “Western Baseline” or with younger cohorts as they age. These patterns suggest that generational “perturbations” matter over and above

life-cycle effects, especially for cohorts socialized during major political ruptures.

Our interviews partially echo this conclusion. Both interviewees in Cohort 1 showed baseline trust on the state, but according to our interview, this trust is not naive or unconditional. Professor X’s expectation is clearly grounded in memories of his youth, where people were just relieved from war but still suffering from a vulnerable state and famine. Therefore it would be hard to judge the state in terms of controlling too much as the state, which possesses primitive power such as the army, relieved them from the Japan Invasion War. Manager Z, of the same generation as Professor X, while highly critical of specific institutional designs such as the “one-and-done” rule in labor arbitration, still expects the state to maintain stability and fairness in areas like public health and pensions (Co1-1). Their trust is therefore structured by cohort-specific memories as much as by their current position in the life cycle.

Younger interviewees, who are at an earlier life stage, do not simply show “low trust because they are young”. Student L’s emphasis on open information and rights, and Student W’s focus on inequality and public ownership, reflect socialization in an era of marketization, digital media, and global references (Co3-1; Co3-2). At the same time, both express expectations that the state should guarantee basic services

and intervene against extreme inequality, which resembles some of the expectations in older cohorts. This suggests that age alone cannot explain their views, and their cognitive framework is strongly shaped by the post-2000 informational and educational context.

Taken together, the interviews support the argument in the fieldwork slides that purely “age-based” explanations are insufficient. The oldest cohort’s continuing trust, the middle cohort’s fairness-oriented demands, and the youngest cohort’s rights-based expectations all remain strongly linked to the historical period of primary socialization, rather than converging along a single life-cycle trajectory.

5.3.3 Impact of education

The overall interviews appear to confirm the hypothesis that education shapes political attitudes, but the comparison suggests that content and type of education matter more than sheer educational level. Educational trajectories supply each cohort with different conceptual tools. Marxist training and later influence of Western thought for the oldest cohort, social science and policy-oriented education for the middle cohort, and global political theory plus digital information environments for the youngest cohort.

In the middle cohort, Teacher Z describes how education and reading reshaped their early conceptions of the state. They recall that *“I used to believe that society, or a state in general couldn’t operate smoothly without the government,”* but exposure to media reports of corruption pushed them toward temporary anarchist sympathies before later study shifted their view again (Co2-2). Apart from the impact of weak institutions, academic engagement with authors such as Alejandro Gimson then helped them to see government and market as coexisting institutions, rather than enemies, and this directly informs their present argument that the state should bear responsibility for welfare and infrastructure while respecting a boundary with civil society.

For the youngest cohort, higher and more diverse educational experiences have made their opinions more global. Student L explicitly connects their views to political theory, explaining that reading Western thinkers like Hobbes and Foucault led them to see the state as necessary for order but also potentially dangerous if not constrained (Co3-1). This education supports the view that legitimate authority must be “limited, rule-bound, and accountable” (paraphrasing Co3-1), and thus supports their insistence on transparent communication: *“free and truthful information exchange is the cornerstone of modern governance”* (Co3-1).

By comparison, the older cohort’s education is more rooted in systematic Marxist-Leninist training. Manager Z in Co1-1 describes being socialized into a coherent theoretical “operating system” during the reform era and then complicating it through exposure to Western social contract thought and Chinese intellectual history. Professor X from cohort 1 is more experience-based, but still reflects a long period of political education that normalized the idea of a strong, paternalistic state. In this sense, education does influence attitudes, but not in a simple “more education leads to more suspicion” way. Rather, different educational contents and epistemic traditions equip cohorts with different languages for describing the state.

5. The Fundamental Mechanisms: Threat, Anxiety, Ideological Trajectories and the Locus of Agency

The previous subsections explained that generational memory, non-age cohort effects, and educational trajectories partly account for why the three cohorts differ in their expectations of the state. However, these factors describe only the sources of variation in their formative experiences rather than the mechanisms through which such experiences are transformed into distinct political attitudes. This section therefore develops the deeper logic behind these differences by examining how threat perception, cohort-specific anxieties, and ideological trajectories work together to shape where each cohort assigns responsibility for public outcomes. In this framework, threat perception refers to the dominant risks encountered during each cohort's formative years; anxiety captures how these risks were internalized into enduring psychological expectations; and ideological trajectories describe how such anxieties crystallised into stable views about the role of the state and the citizen. Together, these mechanisms explain why generational differences persist even when surface-level factors partially converge. They also clarify why the most fundamental mechanism behind these cohort differences is the locus of agency, that the way interviewees decide who should act, who should prevent failures, and who should be blamed.

6.1 Threat Perception and the Formation of Generational Anxiety

Generational differences in expectations of the state become clearer when we examine how interviewees internalize different forms of perceived threat. These threats, rooted in their formative political-economic environments, shape distinct and generational divergent anxieties about what might fail in society and therefore what the state must guarantee. Threat perception thus provides the mechanism through which earlier experiences of scarcity, marketization, and digitalisation are translated into political expectations.

Across interviews from cohort 1, one classic pattern is that threats associated with the inadequate and missing material survival produce an anxiety centred on stability and welfare. When interviewees describe periods in which traditional social buffers disappeared, they repeatedly refer to the uncertainty created by “proletarianisation,” a condition where people were “particularly prone to anxiety” because they lacked independent resources to stabilize their lives (Co1-2). Professor X here specifically mentioned his feeling of a grand transformation from collectivism to 1980s marketization: “We live in an individualized society, not the collective society of the past, and we're not as dependent on the collective anymore.” Sun describes this transformation as the emergence of a “risk society,” in which the collapse of collective welfare systems made the state the only remaining stabilizing force for ordinary households.²² Moreover, the “risk society” also implied an increase in the unpredictability of the government, as Manager Z said in the interview about her company's arbitration: “no one disappears into a black hole, and responsibility is assigned.” Such responsibility declines while the government is gradually withdrawing from citizens' lives compared to the past, deepening the emotion of anxiety, reflecting witnessing institutional inconsistency during early reforms. This materially grounded anxiety orients

²² Sun, Liping. 2009. “China's Risk Society.” *Chinese Sociological Review* 42 (1): 5-25.

responsibility upward: the state becomes the primary actor expected to prevent hardship and maintain basic dignity, and failures are interpreted as insufficient and unpredictable protection rather than excessive intervention, as Inglehart and Baker argue, generations socialized during periods of rapid transformation tend to prioritize stability.²³

A second pattern emerges from cohort 2 where the dominant perceived threat concerns institutional fairness and administrative procedures rather than physical survival. Interviewee who emphasises that high public service quality, strong regulatory enforcement, or disciplinary bureaucratic practices secures public confidence from failures of institutional design(Co2-2). From the early experience with the bureau of human resources and social security, teacher Z shows strong satisfaction from a “friendly and helpful” reception, “clear instructions”, as well as “simple procedures”. Such expectations are a sheer contradiction to inconsistent governmental practices. This pattern echoes Zhang and Ong’s observation that market reforms produced new insecurities linked to bureaucratic arbitrariness, making procedural consistency a central public expectation.²⁴ Accounts such as the frustration with commercialized public services or the insistence that “both substantive and procedural fairness” must be met (Co2-1; Co2-2) illustrate an anxiety centred on fairness, predictability, and rule-bounded governance to “respecting citizens’ right to know and participate, which is crucial for building public trust”(Co2-1). In these cases, responsibility is not located solely in the state but distributed across regulatory systems, administrative procedures, and professional standards, showing that urban professionals increasingly judge state legitimacy through the lens of legal rationality.²⁵

A third pattern appears from cohort 3 where interviewees express concerns about informational reliability and transparency in a digital and globalized environment. For them, the central threat is not insufficient welfare or unfair institutions. Statements such as “free and truthful information exchange is the cornerstone of modern governance” or calls for verifiable and timely official updates (Co3-1; Co3-2) show how informational uncertainty produces an anxiety focused on transparency and communicative legitimacy. In particular, student L insists that when facing government failures “clear explanations, formal apologies, and timely updates,” are required and “open communication, not suppression or cover-ups” are emphasized. This reflects a Habermasian understanding of the public sphere, where legitimacy derives from communicative action.²⁶ But it also aligns with Qiang’s findings that digital-native Chinese youth have heightened expectations of informational rights.²⁷ On the other hand, student W prioritizes “authenticity” and digital verification like “official app notifications to ensure authenticity” which makes the government more credible and reliable. His concerns align with recent scholarship suggesting that digital governance creates new expectations for state responsiveness and data reliability.²⁸ Under this logic, responsibility becomes

²³ Inglehart, Ronald, and Wayne Baker. 2000. “Modernization, Cultural Change, and the Persistence of Traditional Values.” *American Sociological Review* 65 (1): 19-51.

²⁴ Zhang, Li, and Aihwa Ong. 2008. “Privatizing China.” *China Journal* 60: 1—0.

²⁵ He, Baogang, and Mark Warren. 2011. “Authoritarian Deliberation: The Deliberative Turn in Chinese Political Development.” *Perspectives on Politics* 9 (2): 269-89.

²⁶ Habermas, Jürgen. 1989. “The Public Sphere: An Encyclopedia Article.” *New German Critique* 3 (1): 45-56.

²⁷ Qiang, Xiao. 2020. “The Rise of the Informed Citizen: Information Rights in China.” *China Information* 34 (3): 221-40.

²⁸ Chen, Y.-C., and A. Cheung. 2022. “Digital Governance and Technocratic Citizenship in China.” *Information, Communication & Society* 25 (6): 789-807.

co-produced, that the state must disclose information openly, and citizens must participate in monitoring and responding to it.

Taken together, these patterns show that threat perception structures the type of anxiety individuals develop, and this anxiety shapes the form of responsibility they expect. Material threats generate stability-oriented expectations; institutional threats produce fairness-oriented expectations; and informational threats lead to transparency-oriented expectations. Threat and anxiety therefore constitute the first step in the deeper mechanism that links generational experience to political attitudes by shaping how individuals interpret public problems and envision appropriate state action.

6.2 Ideological Trajectories and the Structuring of State Expectations

Distinct forms of anxiety not only shape how individuals interpret public problems but also crystallise into durable ideological trajectories that structure their understanding of the state. These trajectories supply the conceptual vocabulary through which interviewees articulate what a legitimate state should do, how authority should be exercised, and how citizens should relate to public institutions. In this sense, without a generational distinction, ideology functions as the interpretive layer linking affective anxieties to more stable expectations about governance.

One recurring trajectory from different cohorts observed in the interviews frames the state as a guardian responsible for ensuring social protection and preventing a return to insecurity. When interviewees describe the disappearance of traditional buffers and the onset of structural precarity, they rely on a language of responsibility that Ernest Gellner associates with “the normative expectation of the state as order.” Narratives from Professor X emphasising on protection, “continuity of welfare”, and the state’s obligation to “take care of ordinary people” from an implicitly internalized socialist norms of state paternalism illustrate how past experiences of vulnerability have evolved into a pragmatic and historically grounded orientation toward strong public authority (Co1-2).²⁹ Simultaneously Lawyer T mentioned the government’s “paternalist role as the ultimate risk-bearer and protector” when referring to her early experiences with natural disasters, reflecting her thoughts more or less under the influence of paternalistic socialist norms. This trajectory interprets legitimacy through the state’s capacity to preserve stability rather than through procedures or participation, reflecting what Zuo calls “scarred pragmatism”: ideology formed through witnessing political upheaval, institutional restructuring, and the protective role of the state.³⁰

A second ideological trajectory arises when individuals rely on fairness, rule-boundedness, and institutional performance to evaluate governance. Here, expectations derive less from paternalistic protection and more from whether institutions act impartially and transparently. Interviewees’ emphasis on “substantive and procedural fairness”, on frustration with commercialized public services and citing theories and ideas from western political scholars like coexistence between the government and private sectors by Grimson, the theory of social contract by Rousseau and the advocacy of “to say everything” by Foucault,

²⁹ Gellner, Ernest. 1983. “The State and Its Society.” *International Affairs* 59 (3): 353-67.

³⁰ Zuo, Daniel. 2021. “Scarred Pragmatism: Generational Political Orientations in Post-Socialist China.” *The China Review* 21 (2): 45-72.

reflect an implicit but unanimously accepted or influenced idea, in which scholars described as ambivalent state-market hybridity: an ideological stance in which market mechanisms are accepted but must be counterbalanced by regulatory intervention and administrative professionalism (Co1-1; Co2-1; Co2-2; Co3-1). As Hoffman notes, the post-reform transformation of public services into consumer-oriented systems intensified such concerns, because administrative interactions increasingly resembled market transactions rather than impartial public provision.³¹ Under this framework, legitimacy depends on predictable procedures and equitable outcomes rather than solely on state strength, which mirrors Ong's notion of "graduated citizenship" as flexible expectations based on situational needs.³²

A third ideological trajectory centres on transparency, information integrity, and communicative legitimacy. Under globalized educational exposure and digital governance norms, individuals who describe "free and truthful information exchange", and "consolidated service information, and actionable explanation mechanisms" as essential to "modern" governance use a normative language characteristic of what recent scholarship calls digital citizenship, as an orientation in which expectations of the state are closely tied to standards of openness, explainability, and real-time communication (Co2-1; Co2-2; Co3-1; Co3-2).³³ This emphasis aligns with Habermas's argument that legitimacy in modern states depends on communicative practices that allow citizens to scrutinize and respond to government action. In this trajectory, legitimacy is measured by whether the state provides accessible and verifiable information and whether citizens can meaningfully participate in public oversight.

Taken together, these ideological trajectories show how distinct anxieties become stabilized into coherent interpretive frameworks. They also clarify why individuals differ not only in their expectations of the state but also in the language they use to justify these expectations. Ideology thus forms the second step in the deeper mechanism linking generational experience to political attitudes by giving individuals a durable lens through which to assign responsibility and evaluate legitimacy.

6.3 Locus of Agency

By analyzing all the factors that shape generational differences, we argue that the most fundamental mechanism behind them is the way each cohort assigns the locus of agency. Before developing our argument, it is useful to clarify what this concept means in our analysis. In this study, we use "locus of agency" to describe where people locate the primary responsibility for solving problems and for failures. Do they expect the central state, local officials, markets, communities, or themselves to act?³⁴ And when things go wrong, who is seen as the proper target of criticism or complaint? This perspective shifts attention from whether people generally "trust" or "distrust" government to how they organize responsibility, which is especially relevant in a system where the state is highly present but also multi-layered.

³¹ Hoffman, Lisa. 2017. "Bureaucratic Neoliberalism in Urban China." *Urban Studies* 54 (13): 3058-3074.

³² Ong, Aihwa. 2006. "Neoliberalism as Exception: Mutations in Citizenship." *Theory, Culture & Society* 23 (2-3): 6-29.

³³ Chen, Y.-C., and A. Cheung. 2022. "Digital Governance and Technocratic Citizenship in China." *Information, Communication & Society* 25 (6): 789-807.

³⁴ Albert Bandura, "Human Agency in Social Cognitive Theory," *American Psychologist* 44, no. 9 (1989): 1175-1184.

Across the three cohorts, shifts in locus of agency are visible in both expectations and blame. These differences become clearer when we consider how each cohort's dominant form of anxiety directs their interpretation of responsibility. In Cohort 1, material insecurity shapes an expectation that the central state must remain the primary actor. Professor X's description of the proletarianization of society, and his insistence that only the government can guarantee pensions, healthcare, and basic welfare (Co1-2), show that he sees ordinary people as structurally dependent on state action. This expectation reflects a fear that, without strong state intervention, basic stability and survival may again be threatened.³⁵ When the system fails, the problem is often interpreted as a misalignment between policy design and citizen needs, but not as a reason to relocate agencies away from the state. Similarly, when Manager Z criticizes labor arbitration procedures, he does so by appealing to what the state ought to do better, rather than calling for non-state actors to take over (Co1-1). In this cohort, the basic question is why the state isn't doing this properly? Instead of why the state is doing this at all?

For Cohort 2, the locus of agency becomes more distributed but remains state-centred in key domains. Teacher Z places primary responsibility on the state for public welfare sectors like transport and healthcare, yet they also recognize the role of citizens and media in exposing injustice and pushing for reform (Co2-2). This reflects their institutional anxiety, shaped by growing up during marketization when inconsistent service quality and weak regulation made fairness -not survival- the primary concern. Lawyer T's experiences during natural disasters reinforce the view that only the state has the capacity for large-scale coordination, but they also emphasize the importance of institutional rules and legal frameworks, suggesting that agency lies particularly in institutional designs (Co2-1).

Cohort 3 relocates the locus of agency more strongly toward citizens and institutions together. Student L insists that the government must provide information and be open to criticism, but also emphasizes the responsibility of citizens to participate and speak out when they see problems (Co3-1). Their statement of "open communication, not suppression" implicitly frames both sides, state and citizens, as agents; in their conception, the state must listen, and citizens must speak (Co3-1).³⁶ This emphasis reflects their informational anxiety: a fear that without transparency and communicative legitimacy, institutional failures may remain hidden and uncorrected. Student W's focus on inequality and regulation similarly suggests that while the state should intervene in the economy, the criteria for such intervention should be shaped by public debate and social demands (Co3-2). When services fail or injustices occur, this cohort tends to ask not only why the state failed but also why institutions allowed this failure, and whether citizens had effective channels to respond.

In summary, across the three cohorts, the comparison suggests that education did matter, but more in terms of content and cognitive tools, as Marxist theory, social science, Western political thought, than simple educational level. Age effects alone cannot explain the patterns we observe; as the fieldwork framework

³⁵ Lucian Pye, *Asian Power and Politics: The Cultural Dimensions of Authority* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1985).

³⁶ Jürgen Habermas, "The Public Sphere: An Encyclopedia Article," *New German Critique* 3, no. 1 (1989): 45-56.

already indicates, non-age cohort effects are strong, and our interviews show that trust and expectations are anchored in childhood and youth experiences rather than converging with age. Shared generational memory of collectivism and early reform, of marketization with weak institutions, of globalization and digital information shapes how each cohort interprets the state, questions legitimacy, and assigns agency. These shared memories, however, translate into distinct forms of generational anxiety, in terms of material, institutional, and informational, that ultimately structure how responsibility is allocated.³⁷ At the same time, there are important commonalities. All three cohorts agree that the government should take primary responsibility for large-scale security and welfare functions, such as national defence, basic public health, and core infrastructure. They differ sharply, however, on how far this responsibility should extend, how the state should be constrained, and who should share responsibility when things go wrong.

Thus, the three forms of anxiety provide the bridge between generational experience and the assignment of agency, and they help explain why generational differences persist even when education levels rise or institutional environments change. These generational contrasts in cognitive frameworks, legitimacy questions, and locus of agency provide the foundation for the subsequent conclusion and discussion.

5. Conclusion and Discussion

The findings show that the three cohorts clearly differ in how they define state responsibility, legitimacy, core issues and, most fundamentally, where they locate the locus of agency. These differences are caused partially by shared generational memory, and partially by the changing social and intellectual environments in which younger cohorts grew up. This pattern suggests that what truly differentiates the cohorts is not whether they “trust” or “distrust” the government in a simple sense, but how they distribute responsibility between the state, institutions and citizens. As age becomes younger and society develops, intellectual experience, exposure to information, and global ideas matter more in growing percentage for shaping attitudes, while early material hardship becomes less central. Therefore, generational cohort effects, rather than age effects, provide the most convincing explanation of the observed differences.

5.1 Implications for Political Socialization Theory

These interview results speak directly to the literature on political socialization and cohort effects, and partly confirm while also modifying the hypotheses we made. The impact of shared generational memory appears important but uneven. For Cohort 1, memories of famine, collectivism and early reform are clearly central, while for Cohort 2 and Cohort 3, ongoing social experience of marketization, corruption, globalization and digital information seems more important than childhood recollections. This pattern suggests that shared memory has some influence, but not as much as classical models might expect,

³⁷ Liping Sun, “China’s Risk Society,” *Chinese Sociological Review* 42, no. 1 (2009): 5-25

Daniel Zuo, “Scarred Pragmatism: Generational Political Orientations in Post-Socialist China,” *The China Review* 21, no. 2 (2021): 45-72

Y.-C. Chen and Anthony Cheung, “Digital Governance and Technocratic Citizenship in China,” *Information, Communication & Society* 25, no. 6 (2022): 789-807.

especially for younger cohorts. At the same time, the impact of age as such appears limited. Our interviews echo Harmel & Yeh's argument that older cohorts do not necessarily converge to a Western baseline of low trust as they age, and our youngest respondents do not simply show low trust "because they are young," but instead construct rights-based and fairness-based expectations from their specific context. Therefore, the results support a non-age effect model in which cohort-specific environments of socialization, rather than the life-cycle, structure differences in attitudes.

Education also emerges as an important but complex factor. It does influence attitudes, but not in a mechanical "more education = more suspicion" way; instead, different educational contents and epistemic traditions equip cohorts with different languages for describing the state. Marxist-Leninist theory, later blended with Western philosophy and Chinese intellectual history, shapes the oldest cohort's moral-historical framework. Social science and policy-oriented education, combined with media exposure to corruption, shape the middle cohort's fairness-oriented and public goods framework. Global political theory and digital information environments shape the youngest cohort's rights-institutions framework. This confirms that political socialization in contemporary China is multi-layered, combining formal education, lived experience and media exposure, and that these layers differ systematically by cohort.

Taken together, the three cohorts also reflect different ideological trajectories. Cohort 1 illustrates an embedded socialist pragmatism, in which paternalistic state norms are reinterpreted through reform-era hardship. Cohort 2 embodies an ambivalent state-market hybridity, combining consumerist expectations with demands for protective regulation. Cohort 3 points toward a normative-pragmatic digital citizenship, where rights-based languages of transparency and participation are translated into concrete expectations for online information, real-time updates, and explainable decision-making. These trajectories further confirm that cohort-specific environments, rather than age alone, structure how citizens imagine the state.

5.2 Implications for Contemporary Chinese State-Society Relations

For state-society relations research, the findings suggest that generational differences add an important layer to understanding how Chinese citizens relate to a strong but evolving state. The strong sense of inequality and anti-privatization trend in Cohort 2 is valuable for understanding midlife crisis plus institutional trust, because it shows how people who benefited from economic growth can still question the fairness of market outcomes and demand protective intervention. Their focus on buses, healthcare and public services also illustrates how everyday experiences with commercialization directly feed into expectations of state responsibility. Meanwhile, the combination of limited government plus strong public regulation in Cohort 3 suggests that some young people are not simply "denationalizing," but rather demanding a more accountable and equitable state. They do not reject the state as such, but ask for a state that is transparent, rights-respecting and responsive to citizen participation.

At the same time, all three cohorts agree that the government should take primary responsibility for large-scale security and welfare functions, which indicates that support for a strong state remains a cross-generational baseline. The differences lie in where they draw the boundary of legitimate intervention,

how they evaluate privatization, and how they expect the state to justify its actions. This pattern suggests that future studies of Chinese state-society relations should pay closer attention to generational variation in cognitive frameworks and locus of agency, rather than treating “the public” as a single actor.

5.3 Research Limitations and Future Directions

This study is limited by the small number of interviewees and the concentration on urban, educated respondents, which restricts the representativeness of the findings. The reliance on qualitative methods means that we cannot generalize the patterns to all Chinese citizens, and we cannot capture intra-cohort differences such as regional, class or gender-based variations. However, the interviews still provide rich, in-depth material that helps us understand the mechanisms behind survey patterns observed in larger studies, such as non-age effects and persistent trust in central government. Future research could combine this type of qualitative analysis with large-N surveys to test the hypotheses generated here, especially regarding generational memory, education content and locus of agency. Longitudinal studies could also track whether younger cohorts maintain their rights-based expectations as they age, or whether new “perturbations” reshape their attitudes in turn.

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Appendix

Co1-1, Manager Z, Female, She/her

Question: “When you think about the role of government today, which areas of life should be the state's responsibility, and which should be left to citizens?”

Probes: “Could you give an example?” What makes that the government's job?

A:

That's a profound question. To be honest, it's so macro that most of us go about our daily lives without giving it deep, structured thought. But since you ask, let me try to think out loud and trace my reasoning.

For me, it really starts with the basic "why" of government. Thinkers like Hobbes and Rousseau laid the groundwork: we come together in a society and empower a state to protect us from chaos and to uphold our collective well-being through laws. So, fundamentally, the state's job is the big, foundational stuff—security, justice, and the basic infrastructure of society that no single individual could realistically build alone.

From that, I'd draw a rough map.

There are clear areas where the state should take the lead. National defense, the police, the court system—these are no-brainers. It also makes sense for the government to handle massive public works, like a national highway network or a public health system, and to ensure a social safety net with things like pensions. The scale and long-term nature of these things demand the coordination and resources of the state.

On the other hand, the real dynamism of a society comes from its people. So, economic activity—opening a business, innovating—should be largely left to the drive and creativity of citizens. The same goes for art, personal faith, and how we choose to spend our free time. Our communities and charitable groups also show how much we can accomplish ourselves, without the state directing every step.

But the most interesting part is the vast middle ground—the areas where it's a partnership. Think about education, healthcare, or the environment. The lines here aren't fixed; they shift based on a country's specific circumstances and challenges.

To make sense of this, I find a strategic framework like SWOT quite helpful. It forces you to look at a nation's internal Strengths and Weaknesses against external Opportunities and Threats. This analysis then dictates whether the state should be leading, following, or collaborating in these "gray zone" areas.

Let me give you a concrete example: elderly care in China.

Our internal weakness is a significant aging population. But there's also an external opportunity in new "silver economy" technologies and models. So, the strategy here is to transform a weakness. What does that mean in practice? The government's job is to set safety standards, provide a basic pension and a care floor for the most vulnerable. But it should also actively create the space and incentives for private companies and community groups to jump in and develop innovative solutions—like smart home care systems or new community nursing models. This makes it the government's job because the scale of the challenge is a national one, but the solutions are too diverse and personal for a one-size-fits-all state approach.

You see a different dynamic in technology. We have a Weakness in some core "chokepoint" technologies and face the external *Threat* of international competition. So, in areas like semiconductor manufacturing, the state absolutely has a role to play in strategic planning and major resource allocation—it's a matter of national and economic security. But in areas where we are strong, like artificial intelligence applications, the state's job is to set the broad rules of the road and then get out of the way, letting companies and entrepreneurs drive innovation.

So, to circle back to your original question: my view is that the state is ultimately responsible for guaranteeing the foundations—the security, the basic fairness, and the large-scale public goods that form the floor of society. Citizens are responsible for building the ceiling—for all the innovation, culture, and

progress that happens above that floor. The space in between is a constant, dynamic negotiation. A society's success, I believe, depends on its ability to continually recalibrate that balance, ensuring the state is a firm foundation, not a ceiling in itself.

Question: From childhood to now, who or what shaped your view of what the state should do (eg parents, teachers, peers)?

Probes: "Have your views changed at any point? When and why?"

Looking back, my views on what the state should do weren't formed overnight. It's been a dynamic process, shaped in three distinct phases.

The real foundation was laid in my youth, during China's reform and opening-up period. The systematic education I received, particularly in Marxist philosophy, was my first and most profound influence. It gave me a kind of "master key" to understanding society. Concepts like the relationship between the productive forces and the relations of production, or the idea that the state is a tool for governance at a specific stage of historical development, shaped my entire "operating system." It taught me that the state's fundamental role was to organize societal production and maintain order. That was my baseline.

The second, and most challenging phase, was my exposure to the West. This happened in my late twenties and thirties, through working in foreign-invested enterprises and some limited travels abroad. It was a real shock to the system. I saw firsthand the emphasis on individual liberty, market dynamism, and a vibrant civil society, which stood in stark contrast to the "collective-first" mindset I was raised with. This forced me to compare and reflect deeply. I began to read about Western political theory—Rousseau's social contract, the idea of the "general will." It opened a new window. I realized that the model of the state I had understood was just one possibility. My view shifted from seeing one "correct" model to understanding that different models were products of their own unique history and context.

This tension led to the third phase: a kind of personal synthesis through reading. I dabbled in everything from Rousseau and Hobbes to Chinese historians like Qian Mu, and even classic novels like *Les Misérables* and *War and Peace*. This eclectic reading helped me move beyond a black-and-white perspective. I began to see that the macro-historical perspective from my Marxist foundation and the Western focus on individual rights weren't entirely incompatible. The former explained the why of the state—its historical necessity and fundamental functions. The latter enriched the how—the specific paths and the crucial need for limits on

power. My current view is a blend: an ideal state is one that, while respecting objective developmental laws, works to maximize societal vitality and individual well-being.

You asked if my views have changed. Absolutely, and fundamentally so.

The biggest shift happened during that "second shock" phase in my thirties. The change was threefold:

From Absolute to Relative: I moved from believing in one "absolutely correct" model of the state to understanding that different models are suited to different historical and social conditions.

From Single to Multiple: I stopped seeing the state purely as a class-based instrument and began to appreciate its multiple roles—as a public service provider, a market regulator, and an actor in the international community.

From Acceptance to Critical Thinking: I stopped accepting any single doctrine at face value, whether Eastern or Western. I developed my own framework for judgment: evaluating what a state should do based on how effectively it balances core goals like security, development, fairness, and freedom within its specific circumstances.

In a nutshell, my intellectual journey has been a classic case of "thesis, antithesis, synthesis." My early education was the thesis, the exposure to the West was the antithesis that challenged it, and my ongoing attempt to forge a personal, integrated understanding is the synthesis.

Question: "Please walk me through the last time you dealt with a public institution"

Probes: "Was this interaction a positive or negative experience?"

You asked about my last interaction with a government agency? It immediately brings to mind a recent labor arbitration case I went through, which gave me a lot to reflect on.

The experience occurred in January 2024, when I appeared at a labor arbitration tribunal in Beijing as the

company's representative. Back in September 2023, we had terminated an employee's contract during their probation period due to failure to meet performance targets. Later, we discovered he had concealed a significant part of his work history in his resume, so we issued a supplemental notice of termination based on resume fraud.

After the hearing, the arbitrator tried to mediate, hinting that offering some compensation might be the easier path. I pressed him on the legal rationale and the broader social impact: wouldn't such a compromise inadvertently encourage dishonest behavior and demoralize conscientious employees in the long run? The arbitrator said he understood but was frank about a key feature of the system—the "one-and-done arbitration" rule. Specifically, for cases where the claimed amount is below 26,000 RMB, the ruling is final and binding for the company, with no right to appeal, while the employee retains the right to take the case to court. He hinted that companies inevitably have procedural flaws, so compromise was the pragmatic choice. While I understood his position, my commitment to procedural justice led me to decline the mediation.

In May 2024, the ruling was issued, determining that our company had wrongfully terminated the contract and must pay double compensation. The arbitrator acknowledged a lower monthly salary base, which objectively reduced the total compensation amount—a fair point. However, the core logic of the ruling was what I found difficult to accept. Our company's internal regulations clearly stated that a contract could be terminated if an employee was "deemed incompetent after training or transfer to another position." Yet, the arbitrator interpreted the word "or" in the clause as "and," ruling that since we had provided training but not a transfer option, the termination was invalid. This semantic shift of a key conjunction fundamentally negated the compliance of our action.

Bound by the "one-and-done" rule, our company lost the right to appeal. We could only apply for a retrial based on "newly discovered evidence," but investing more resources to find what was nearly impossible new evidence for a limited claim amount is unrealistic for most businesses. We ultimately complied with the ruling.

Later, I consulted the Labor Bureau informally about the fairness of this case. A part-time arbitrator offered an unofficial perspective: he believed our company wasn't entirely blameless, as our background checks weren't thorough enough, and suggested we improve our processes in the future.

If you're asking whether this interaction was a positive or negative experience, I must say it was largely negative.

My frustrations stemmed mainly from three aspects:

Structural Bias in System Design: The "one-and-done arbitration" rule, while perhaps well-intentioned to protect employees perceived as the vulnerable party, creates a structural imbalance in rights. It objectively restricts one party's fundamental right to recourse, potentially amplifying any misjudgment inherent in a single ruling and leading to perceived injustice.

Compromise of Values in Implementation: I sensed that arbitrators, under pressure to close cases and minimize appeal risks, tend to favor a "muddying the waters" approach to mediation. When procedural justice and the rule of law are sidelined for the sake of "maintaining stability" and reducing disputes, it reflects not a pure spirit of rule of law but what I see as a "banality of evil" that erodes established rules.

Disconnect Between Professional Judgment and Reality: Elevating an imperfection in our background check into the decisive reason for bearing full legal liability shows a cognitive disconnect from the practical complexities of daily business management. If this mindset is prevalent among enforcement officials, it will not only damage business confidence but, in the long run, erode the government's own credibility and governance efficacy.

Finally, I'd like to add a related observation. During recent informal conversations with friends in the Industry & Commerce and Tax bureaus, I learned that a significant number of small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) in Beijing collapsed between 2023 and 2024. Apparently, arbitration policy initially leaned towards preserving jobs to ensure social stability. Now, the enforcement climate seems to be swinging back, attempting to show more support for businesses. Yet, regrettably, many companies were already overburdened and have quietly shut down. The lag of this policy pendulum adjustment behind the real-life fate of market entities stands as a poignant regret of our time.

Question: "When government services do not work as expected, what exactly should the government do for you to consider the response fair?"

Probes: “Do you expect them to communicate with you (explanation, apology, updates)?” “What channel do you expect them to communicate with you (email, app, no need)?”

For me, a fair response from the government when a service fails isn't about perfection; it's about demonstrating that the system is predictable, open to dialogue, and capable of learning. My sense of fairness hinges on a process that operates on three levels.

First, there must be Procedural Justice—the basic respect for rules. I need to see an immediate, formal process kick in. This means receiving an acknowledgment with a unique case number, a clear point of contact, and a timeline. It's the fundamental promise of a functioning bureaucracy: no one disappears into a black hole, and responsibility is assigned.

But that's just the start. Second, I need Communicative Justice. I'm less interested in an apology than in a sincere explanation. Once the process is over, I expect a written statement that doesn't just state a conclusion but clarifies why the failure happened—was it a rule gap, human error, or a misapplication?—and explicitly cites the regulations involved. Most importantly, if my complaint was valid, it should outline what internal steps will be taken to prevent a recurrence. This isn't about placating me; it's about proving the system can engage in public reason and self-correct.

Ultimately, what I value most is the third layer: Systemic Justice. Does my single case contribute to a larger improvement? A government that truly serves the common good has mechanisms to analyze complaints for patterns. For instance, if my labor arbitration issue is part of a wider trend, will the relevant department issue new guidance or review the problematic rule? This shows the government is responsive to the "general will," not just putting out individual fires.

In short, fairness is conveyed through a consistent reverence for the rules themselves—from initiating a transparent process, to communicating with evidence, and finally, using that experience to optimize the system for everyone.

On your follow-up question about communication, my strong preference is for official email or a message through a government service portal. These channels provide a written, traceable record that ensures seriousness and accuracy. They form a reliable basis for any future

Col-2, Professor X, Male, He/His

Q: If you were to explain in your own words, what do you think the country should be doing today, and what should citizens be doing?

A: That's a very broad question. For example, infrastructure development, economic growth, political corruption, and human trafficking—these all need to be addressed. These all relate to every aspect of people's lives. You can ask for more specific questions.

Q: Many people, especially our generation, seem to feel that the government is interfering too much, or not interfering well. There are frequent protests, and leaflets are being posted in schools. What's your view on this? Do you think these things are still within the government's responsibilities, just not being done well?

A: Your answer might surprise you. I would say it's a kind of anxiety, you know, a kind of anxiety that's very common in our history. The government's involvement in these matters has inertia. Why did it intervene in the past? Because of anxiety, because the people wanted it to intervene. Now, saying no is also due to anxiety. We live in an individualized society, not the collective society of the past, and we're not as dependent on the collective anymore. My daughter and I, who are about your age, are still unfamiliar with terms like grid workers and community street offices.

Actually, since 1949, our generation has experienced a one-size-fits-all proletarianization. Those of you who study politics should know what this means. Originally, there was still some middle class in society, even if it was very fragile, but later it was basically scattered. In the discourse of the system, everyone is now "proletarian" and "working people." You have to go to the countryside and do labor. It sounds glorious, but there is a very real consequence, which you can see now: once you are "proletarian," you are particularly prone to anxiety. When you are anxious, you say, "You have to manage this and that." But you took things away from us! In the past, if peasants had a famine, they could turn to landlords and gentry. You know, a rigid society, right? Historical research on the Qing Dynasty shows that it was a rigid society back then. Who would take care of the grassroots under such rigidity? You say you're studying grassroots governance, yes, but it's all about clans and local gentry, respected elders. To put it bluntly, you've destroyed all that, you've taken everything away. I'm not saying it's bad, but I was fine before, now there's trouble. If you don't take responsibility, who will? And because there's no buffer zone. If you're middle class with some savings, you can weather the storm; a slight rise in prices, a fluctuation in income, you can grit your teeth and bear it. But now we're all what we call the general public. Back then, things were better; it wasn't as modern and

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commercialized as it is now. It was just a monthly salary, public healthcare, nothing else. So once the system loosens, the market winds blow, there's widespread anxiety. Anxiety creates demand, and the government has to respond to demand—that's its foundation. You have no choice. And you might not really say you don't need it anymore, right? I don't know how many data surveys you've done, but from my perspective, this kind of management is still very necessary.

Q2: You mentioned that all of this stems from anxiety. Do you feel that this anxiety became more pronounced after the 1990s, or after economic reforms and marketization?

A: Yes, there was anxiety in the 1980s too, but back then it was more about the anxiety of our knowledge structure being impacted by new knowledge. There was constant talk of catching up with the West, making up for lost time, and aligning our culture and systems—that was also anxiety, an anxiety of perspectives.

The 1980s were the era of state-owned enterprises. They even laughed at private vendors reselling jeans. Work was so precious back then; they'd laugh and say, "Go ahead and jump around! Do you have any money to jump around? Do you have public medical care? Do you have a pension? You have a monthly salary, medical insurance, and I'd say your house is practically free. Do you have any anxieties about life?" Actually, you don't. Only the farmers suffer. As I said, before, landlords and gentry took care of them; now, who takes care of them? Everyone wanted urban residency, and the government had a policy of supporting industry through agriculture. These were all brutal accumulations. You had to pay taxes, and agricultural grain—that was public grain—it was all propaganda, supposedly to support national construction! Who cared if the farmers had enough to eat? During the Great Leap Forward, right? Actually, they didn't care enough. Farmers lived inhuman lives. My father went to the countryside; his landlord was a soldier, and the whole family shared one military-issue quilt. Later, he left his own quilt there. And that's not all. During the Cultural Revolution, sometimes you could only cover yourself with sand. You'd carry it out by hand during the day—it's ridiculous, isn't it?—and then bring it back at night; at least it was warm. Sometimes you ask what the government should be doing. I'm not speculating; I can roughly guess what you want to write, but since you've asked me, I'll say it: they really didn't care enough, or rather, they didn't care about what they should have. So many people froze and starved to death. Engineers, soldiers, merchants, and intellectuals were all vested interest groups; farmers weren't.

But for these groups, those were good times. The government supported them financially, and they had ideals and dreams. That era was characterized by grand narratives, a legacy of collectivism. There was no individualism then; it was all grand narratives—art and culture alike. That's why you see those artists from the 1990s, the ones being discussed online now, painting nudes, depicting mistresses—it's incomprehensible. Why? Because we live in an overly individualistic, atomized era, unlike before.

Okay, I've digressed. It's essentially about inequality. I think that once the economy reaches a certain level, you must shift your focus to social policy to support that large, unemployed population, a significant portion of whom still lack social security in rural areas. Otherwise, when per capita income reaches three to five thousand US dollars, there's a risk of "Latin Americanization." If you study economics, you know what I mean.

Q: So, back to our question, what do you think citizens should do?

A: Just surviving and obeying the law is difficult enough; you can't expect too much. So many cases of human trafficking and early marriage still exist in rural areas. People online think we're modernized and everyone's educated, but that's not true. China is a vast country; Wuhan is just a tiny fraction of the population. There are so many people living underground; researchers need to reach them. It's not that people aren't eating or dressing well, but the overall material standard of living isn't that high. You need to ensure everyone's basic needs are met before talking about taking responsibility for yourself or getting personal insurance. With so many scams these days, who buys insurance? Even if they do, they'll get scammed. I think it's only meaningful for citizens to talk about responsibility, self-governance, and participation under these conditions. It's not the right time yet.

Q: How do you see the cultural changes resulting from the economic changes since the reforms, and the recent wave of nationalism?

A: You've also seen some phenomena. Many prominent figures from the 1980s have become disillusioned, some even turning to nationalism or populism. I don't think it's because they personally turned bad, but rather that the environment became too complex. Globalization brought economic, institutional, and cultural dimensions all intertwined. Society became frantically Westernized and market-driven, and then information overloaded everything, leading to urbanization, industrialization, and an atomized society. Those of us who write sentimental articles are the most aware of this; your old "grand narrative" knowledge structure is no longer applicable.

Many people used to pull out a single, overarching argument or prescribe a grand remedy, such as "criticizing Confucius, criticizing tradition, destroying the Four Olds, and then categorizing all of Loess Plateau civilization as backward," ultimately leading to a total rejection like in "River Elegy."

But starting in the 1990s, this way of thinking itself began to fail. People experienced a structural sense of powerlessness—you feel like something's wrong, but you can't find a master switch to turn things off. There

were two kinds of evaluations at the time. One was that commercialism disrupted or loosened this ideology, providing personal space. People born after the 1970s formed their knowledge in such a relaxed environment, hence their individuality. The other was critical, for example, the New Left, which emphasized the influence of commerce on education. But these perspectives are inherently one-dimensional, stemming from the views of Singaporean or Frankfurt School thinkers. Capitalist commercial culture shapes one-dimensional individuals; you might have been politically unidirectional before, or technologically or consumerist now. However, in my opinion, Singapore and Malaysia face mature capitalism. Europe has largely resolved its wealth gap, right? The environment is very different. They have a mature market economy, which cannot be directly applied to ours.

Returning to your previous question, the reasons for Latin American collapse are similar. We can't simply copy their methods. If per capita income is around 1,000, you need to start implementing welfare programs; otherwise, you won't be able to afford 5,000, and you'll collapse at 3,000. At such times, some will inevitably retreat to nationalism and populism because those are readily available narrative frameworks. You always have a path dependency, feeling that the problem lies with external factors, with cultural roots, with others taking things from us. In reality, it's a loss of control over discourse.

Q: You just mentioned that we are not yet ready for modern commercialization. Could you elaborate?

A: Actually, it's not about commercialization; we don't have commerce at all. What is commerce? Commerce is a credit market; you need a sound credit system. We don't have that, nor a financial system, so how can we talk about commerce? To put it bluntly, it's basically robbery, and it's still robbery now. Some people rob more, some less; state-owned assets are privatized, and then the stock market crashes. This is a cruel but undeniable problem.

Q: There's a book called "The Modernization Trap," which discusses how state-owned assets are transferred to those with power and connections who can control them.

A: Yes, yes, how is that commerce? Weber talks about the spirit of capitalism and the Protestant ethic. Right now, China is just releasing some resources; whoever has the ability, whoever is closest to the source, gets their hands on them. This isn't commerce. Without a supreme authority, it's equivalent to a state of nature, even a barbaric one. We're not in a state of nature. After so many years of reform and opening up, opening up centralized resources, and releasing them level by level—what was held in our hands could only be released downwards to create a market—all of this should have been resolved by the late 1980s. But this aspect froze for over a decade, and some people started robbing. Corruption and robbery are inseparable. So, is there a problem with the market? The market is too small.

Q: Returning to our interview topic, how do you think the political attitudes of this generation (50-60 years old) have been shaped? Compared to the previous and next generations, what is special about them?

A: The generation during the Cultural Revolution was actually influenced by this widespread ideology, not only through propaganda but also through later books, repeated emphasis in classes and performances. You'll find that the authors at the time were also influenced by this ideology in their later narratives. You know, many who participated in persecution and beatings later portrayed themselves as pure victims. How do you explain this? It's not just a matter of personal memory; it's a systemic cover-up. This generation emerged from a cultural rupture, so many of their narratives have a kind of "desert syndrome"—on the one hand, their accounts are exaggerated, and on the other hand, they are distorted. For example, Lu Xun said, "I will not forgive a single one." If this statement doesn't include himself, then that's his blind spot. Many people after the Cultural Revolution had this blind spot: they only saw their own suffering and were unwilling to consider whether they had harmed others. If you truly want to live with dignity, you have to weigh the consequences. Even if you can't say it publicly, you should know in your heart what that experience meant to others. But many people don't think about it; they don't even consider this. Everyone is affected, but life still goes on.

That's why I never argue with my father about his political beliefs. It was the most important life experience for him from adolescence to—what, being labeled a rightist—that was the most important period of his life. Asking him to completely deny it would be like taking his life; it would be like forcing him to overturn his entire set of values and beliefs and start over. For many people, the Cultural Revolution, the May Fourth Movement, and the 1980s are so important in their narratives because they represent the most brilliant, most tragic, or perhaps most intense period of their personal lives. You need to understand this to understand his way of expressing himself today.

So, when you talk about the influence of "isms" and the Cultural Revolution ideology on people, I think on the one hand, they truly shaped people's anxieties, beliefs, and storytelling styles. On the other hand, people also use their own narratives and memories to influence those isms and those eras, sometimes unconsciously, in a way. These two directions are always intertwined. Many people themselves are unaware of this.

For example, modern capitalism, frankly speaking, elevates efficiency to a godlike status, requiring you to be on high alert at all times. Work must be highly efficient, life must be highly efficient, you must seize every spare moment, even learning on your commute, right? You can only succeed if you keep up with this efficiency, or even exceed this standard, but this creates anxiety. So there's always anxiety. If China

increasingly builds itself according to what we call a standardized capitalist economic society, then this anxiety will definitely rise along with it. Modernization has come a long way, and much of our traditional culture and lifestyle has been lost. Many simple ways of life have disappeared. Adults and children alike are constantly on edge, afraid of being left behind. Holidays are no longer celebrated, and the pressure on teenagers increases year by year. It's a vicious cycle from which you can't escape.

This problem began as early as the late Qing Dynasty, with the May Fourth Movement generation. Back then, there was a sense of urgency, a desire for national salvation, a need to survive, and a demand for Western learning. Everyone was searching for an ideology to suppress their inner anxieties. After a period of turmoil until the founding of the People's Republic in 1949, the anxiety suddenly subsided. People finally felt, "Hey, I've found Marxism-Leninism! I have the answer!" Even when things broke down with the Soviet Union, they weren't anxious; they could still write the "Nine Commentaries," meaning, "Don't panic, we have the right, we can criticize, and we can even save socialism." That sense of confidence was there. But what about now? Today it's one concept, tomorrow it's another, and everyone reflexively rushes to it, essentially searching for something to combat anxiety.

From this perspective, I actually feel that our generation, and even today's young people, haven't changed much. Even if their views have shifted somewhat, overall, they still share the same set of ideas, making them particularly vulnerable to the test of time. It's like a monkey's butt being on fire. For example, there's the saying, "Ten thousand years is too long, seize the day," right? Five-year plans, ten-year plans—it always feels like the world is ending if things can't be solved in a year or two. But if you really stretch the timeframe to five hundred or a thousand years, these ideologies, lines, and slogans don't even qualify as historical units of measurement. Most of the anxieties that seem so great now will eventually pass.

So, as I said before, the history and memories of my generation influenced people, caused anxiety, and now, people's own narratives and memories rewrite those things. Sometimes it's genuine reflection, but ultimately you'll find that these two directions are intertwined and mutually influential, with a counterforce.

Co2-1, Lawyer T, Female, She/her

Question: “When you think about the role of government today, which areas of life should be the state's responsibility, and which should be left to citizens?”

Probes: “Could you give an example?” What makes that the government's job?

A: The government should primarily be responsible for constructing infrastructure and social safety nets, such as transportation hubs and emergency management systems. This reflects its core function as a "night watchman," ensuring fundamental social order and citizen safety. In the cultural sphere, I support a model led by citizen autonomy and societal pluralism. The vitality of cultural development stems from free societal creativity and organic interaction; excessive state intervention could stifle the diversity of the cultural ecosystem. This aligns with the core tenet of Limited Government Theory regarding the need for a clear demarcation between state and civil society.

Question: From childhood to now, who or what shaped your view of what the state should do (eg parents, teachers, peers)?

Probes: “Have your views changed at any point? When and why?”

A: My perception was shaped by two key experiences: The first was personally experiencing major natural disasters in childhood. (big earthquake, flood and wildfire) .During these crises, the government demonstrated strong mobilization and relief capabilities, profoundly illustrating its paternalist role as the ultimate risk-bearer and protector. The second was systematic civic education, particularly history lessons, which provided a rational framework for understanding government functions and legitimacy from legal and historical perspectives.

Question:” Please walk me through the last time you dealt with a public institution”

Probes: “Was this interaction a positive or negative experience?”

A: My most recent interaction is to renew my driver's license was an efficient and standardized service experience. The process was clear and the staff were professional.

Question: “When government services do not work as expected, what exactly should the government do for you to consider the response fair”

Probes: “Do you expect them to communicate with you (explanation, apology, updates)?” “What channel do you expect them to communicate with you (email, app, no need)?”

A: When public services fail, a fair response should encompass both substantive and procedural dimensions. Substantively, timely financial compensation or equivalent service restitution should be provided to rectify the failure. Procedurally, I expect the government to proactively provide updates and explanations through modern channels like official apps or email. This is not merely about correcting outcomes but also about respecting citizens' right to know and participate, which is crucial for building public trust.

Co2-2, Teacher Z, Male, He/his

Question: “When you think about the role of government today, which areas of life should be the state's responsibility, and which should be left to citizens?”

Probes: “Could you give an example?” What makes that the government's job?

A: In my opinion, state should take charge of social welfares and infrastructure construction. Because those sectors are not meant to be lucrative, in contrast, their purpose is to fulfil citizens’ daily necessities. Private ownership’s potential seizure of those industries could lead to the decline of service quality, as private entrepreneurs would always prioritize the maximization of profits.

For example, a considerable number of bus routes in Beijing are running with an income deficit, especially those operate in remote suburbs, while passengers are primarily elders who ride for free. If public transportation is privatized, those less profitable routes would be cancelled straight away, causes considerable inconvenience to ALL commuters. Similarly, healthcare shall not be left to individual enterprises, as the pursuit of extra income only results in overdiagnosis, excessive prescription and inaccessibility of basic medical attention to most commoners.

Apart from those above-mentioned areas, I believe that citizens’ participation or incentives shall not be confined.

Question: From childhood to now, who or what shaped your view of what the state should do (eg parents, teachers, peers)?

Probes: “Have your views changed at any point? When and why?”

A: Well it’s a long story. I used to believe society, or a state in general couldn’t operate smoothly without the government. However I become sort of uncertain later on (like when I was 15 or 16, to such an extent I even embraced Anarchism for few years) because I have been exposed to countless reports of corruption or scandals within bureaucracy. Providing handsome paychecks and bonus for all the public servants who literally do nothing is definitely a huge financial burden for all taxpayers. Not to mention all types of nepotism observed during the decision-making process.

But my perception on this issue was reshaped by Alejandro Grimson, professor of Anthropology and Sociology at University of Buenos Aires, to a certain degree. Argentina, as many of us know, it’s also a country divided by the chronical public disagreement on the role of government. Liberals, particularly after

the inauguration of Javier Milei in 2023, have always been championed or even cherished the limited presence of state. However at the meantime, Grimson argues that the government has been demonized, while the reason behind it is that most of us never truly comprehend the role it should play. To explain, Grimson suggests that the government and private sector shall not compete but COEXIST. Many sectors or social services can't also shouldn't be entrusted to citizens to start with. My answer for Question I is inspired by him.

Question: "Please walk me through the last time you dealt with a public institution"

Probes: "Was this interaction a positive or negative experience?"

A: Last time I dealt with a public institution? It was July 2024. At that moment I just resigned from my previous job, so in this case I had to pay medical assurance and pension deposit myself. So I went to the bureau of human resources and social security within the subdistrict where I live and settled things down.

I would rank that experience positively. The receptionist was friendly and helpful, instruction was quite clear, and to my surprise, the procedures were not that complicated.

Question: "When government services do not work as expected, what exactly should the government do for you to consider the response fair"

Probes: "Do you expect them to communicate with you (explanation, apology, updates)?" "What channel do you expect them to communicate with you (email, app, no need)?"

A: Definitely! If the service fails to meet my expectations I shall be addressed appropriately and in a timely manner. I am a citizen of this certain country, which means I am entitled to that.

And I don't have a preference for the "channel". As long as I can be reached on time, all measures are welcomed! And I think that it's not so hard for the government to do that since we are living in the digital age.

Co3-1, Student L, Female, She/her

Question: "When you think about the role of government today, which areas of life should be the state's responsibility, and which should be left to citizens?"

Probes: "Could you give an example?" What makes that the government's job?

A:

I believe the state should primarily focus on ensuring the basic conditions for individuals to live securely and freely. This includes protecting individuals' fundamental rights to self-preservation by maintaining order, security, and justice. These responsibilities align with the government's role as a guarantor of the collective good.

At the same time, I also believe that citizens must retain significant autonomy and agency in public life. The government should not monopolize power or suppress voices but instead create conditions that encourage civic participation and allow free expression. Citizens should have the freedom to organize, express their concerns, and hold the government accountable.

For instance, areas such as national defense, public infrastructure, and public health (e.g., pandemic responses) fall squarely within the government's domain, as they require coordinated, large-scale efforts beyond the capacity of individual citizens. However, areas such as community governance, cultural expression, and grassroots initiatives should be left to the citizens, as these foster a sense of agency and prevent overreach of state power.

When the government overextends its role, it risks undermining the very freedoms it is supposed to protect. Thus, a balance must be struck: the government should act as a facilitator of security and fairness while ensuring that citizens can meaningfully participate in shaping their own lives and communities.

Question: From childhood to now, who or what shaped your view of what the state should do (eg parents, teachers, peers)?

Probes: "Have your views changed at any point? When and why?"

A:

Throughout my life, I haven't paid particular attention to political issues, and therefore haven't systematically reflected on my clear views on what kind of role should the government play. However, I think the process of my shift in these views might be from passively accepting school education and government propaganda and being content with the status quo to beginning my own thinking. A large part of what shaped my perspective came from the political philosophy aspects of the theories of various thinkers I encountered after beginning to study the history of Western philosophy. Regarding the role and obligations of the state, Hobbes's assumption about the state of nature dictates that, in order to escape the state of war where "man is a wolf to man" (*homo homini lupus*), rational humanity must, through two covenants and three natural laws, transfer some of its rights to guarantee its fundamental natural right of peace and self-preservation.

Regarding the role of government in people's lives, Foucault has been very enlightening to me. From his etymological examination, I learned that the word "people" we use today traces back to its close connection

with "freedom" in ancient Greece—libertas-the people (die leute in German, Liber in archaic Latin, laos or leos in ancient Greek = ἐλευθερία" is the freedom of Greeks.) Therefore, the people should not be entirely passive in the face of the government, but should participate to a great extent in public affairs. This relies on Foucault's emphasis on "Parrèsia" (Pan "all" + rhèsis "word, speech", "to say everything"), meaning the people should have the right to free expression without being persecuted by the government.

In the real life, it is mainly certain social events that prompt me to reflect on this topic. These events often demonstrate, from the opposite perspective, the difficulties faced by people's livelihoods due to excessive government power. These range from small-scale incidents such as in Wukan(乌坎) village, officials abusing their power to sell villagers' real estate, abolishing the villagers' self-elected committee, and even killing village representatives and covering up the truth, to larger-scale incidents such as the Chinese government's well-documented handling of the COVID-19 pandemic highlighted similar themes.

Question:” Please walk me through the last time you dealt with a public institution”

Probes: “Was this interaction a positive or negative experience?”

A:

Even the most recent time was many months ago when I went to the government service center to renew my passport. I didn't have any particular feelings or impressions; it was a positive experience. I remember there were a lot of people queuing, but the order was very good. The division of labor at each window was clear and efficient, and the signs were quite clear. The staff member who took my photo even noticed that my hair wasn't neatly styled in the photo after I had already received it and offered to let me come back to take another photo without having to queue again.

Question: “When government services do not work as expected, what exactly should the government do for you to consider the response fair”

Probes: “Do you expect them to communicate with you (explanation, apology, updates)?” “What channel do you expect them to communicate with you (email, app, no need)?”

A:

The government should demonstrate responsibility and fairness in addressing public service failures. So, when government obligations are not fulfilled, the government has a responsibility to rebuild trust by transparently handling the errors, correcting the problems, and ensuring they do not recur.

Communication is clearly crucial. When government services fail, the state should proactively communicate with affected citizens, providing clear explanations, formal apologies, and timely updates on corrective measures. In my opinion, an ideal government's relationship with the people must be built on open

communication, not suppression or cover-ups. Free and truthful information exchange is the cornerstone of the normal functioning of the public sphere. To ensure inclusive and efficient communication, it should be conducted through convenient channels; I believe there are now many applications specifically developed for this purpose in China.

Co3-2, Student W, Male, He/his

Question: “When you think about the role of government today, which areas of life should be the state's responsibility, and which should be left to citizens?”

Probes: “Could you give an example?” What makes that the government's job?

When I think of the role of state today, the first word that came to my mind was 'limited government.' In most societies, a democratically elected government represents the state, and the government's rights and responsibilities have been clarified by constitution and laws. In most countries, the constitution and the laws have given the government the right to form the budget, to lead the armed forces within the states territory, and to tax it's citizens. I think that the government has the following responsibilities: The government should regulate the economy and promote equality for the working people, which consists the majority of the society. The government should also maintain social order and construct a safe society, and defend the national interests of the state. Meanwhile, The citizens have the responsibility to engage in politics, to shape the nations future, and to organise their local communities for self-governance.

Question: From childhood to now, who or what shaped your view of what the state should do (eg parents, teachers, peers)?

Probes: “Have your views changed at any point? When and why?”

In my childhood, I travelled across the country and witnessed the arduous living conditions of many impoverished communities. Yet at that time, I did not comprehend the causes nor the mechanisms of poverty; I merely believed the government should guarantee a minimum standard of living for the poor. Not after long, I transferred from an international school to a public primary school attended by children of peasants and workers. From that point, I gradually immersed myself among them, listening to the problems they encountered in daily life and the processes by which these difficulties arose. I realised that under private ownership and a liberal Market economy, achieving any form of equality and justice for the working class is impossible. I believe the government's responsibility is to maintain public ownership of essential public services and to establish strong public ownerships across major economic sectors. Building upon this foundation, the market must be subject to stringent regulation. This approach would advance social equality and justice, thereby weakening the roots of poverty.

Question:” Please walk me through the last time you dealt with a public institution”

Probes: “Was this interaction a positive or negative experience?”

My last interaction with a public institution was when I visited the Human Resources and Social Security Bureau to process my academic records and obtain certification for university applications before studying abroad. One document, issued by my secondary school, faced reluctance from the clerk to stamp it, as it was not issued directly from the Education Bureau. After negotiations, they ultimately agreed to stamp on it. The experience was positive overall. Yet it serves as a reminder that within the boundaries of regulations and personal convenience, both citizens and the public institution should maintain flexibility while adhering to the fundamental principles of the rules, thereby upholding mutual trust in society.

Question: “When government services do not work as expected, what exactly should the government do for you to consider the response fair”

Probes: “Do you expect them to communicate with you (explanation, apology, updates)?” “What channel do you expect them to communicate with you (email, app, no need)?”

When government services do not work as expected, I believe the matter should be addressed by considering several different scenarios. If the issue stems from technical problems, the government should provide a thorough explanation of the circumstances. When errors occur within government services, they ought to apologise and promptly compensate for any associated consequences. Where legal regulations are unclear, government services should offer updates once the relevant laws and regulations have been clarified, and swiftly identify methods to address the citizen's needs. Regarding follow-up methods, I would prefer government services to communicate with me via their official app to ensure the authenticity of their notifications. An additional benefit of the app lies in its ability to consolidate all information related to government services.